

City Routes

Chengdu → Chongqing →

Zhangjiajie: Pandas, Hotpot &

Avatar Mountains (6-7 Days)

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# Chengdu → Chongqing → Zhangjiajie: Pandas, Hotpot & Avatar Mountains (6-7 Days)

This 6-7 day route combines three of China's most exciting destinations: Chengdu's laid-back panda paradise, Chongqing's cyberpunk mountain city, and Zhangjiajie's otherworldly pillar mountains that inspired Avatar's floating Hallelujah Mountain. It's a journey from Sichuan's numbing-spicy cuisine through Chongqing's fiery hotpot to Hunan's aromatic peppers -- with some of the most dramatic natural scenery on Earth.

## Day 1-2: Chengdu -- Slow Living Capital

Day 1 Morning: Chengdu Research Base of Giant Panda Breeding

(成都大熊猫繁育研究基地)

Arrive early -- gates open at 7:30 AM and the pandas are most active before 10 AM (after that, they're napping). The base houses 200+ pandas across different ages. The star attraction is the nursery where you can watch baby pandas tumbling over each other. Take the internal shuttle bus (¥10) to save 30 minutes of walking. Book tickets online at least 2 days in advance via WeChat -- walk-in tickets are extremely limited.

07:30-18:00 | ¥55 | ! Book online in advance

Day 1 Afternoon: Jinli Ancient Street (锦里古街) & Wuhou Shrine (武侯祠)

Adjacent to each other, these two sites make a perfect afternoon pairing. Wuhou Shrine is a tranquil temple complex dedicated to Zhuge Liang (the legendary strategist from Romance of the Three Kingdoms). Step outside into Jinli Ancient Street -- a 550m pedestrian lane packed with Sichuan snack stalls, teahouses, and handicraft shops. Try the three-shot tea (盖碗茶) performance and watch Sichuan face-changing opera (变脸)

performers.

08:00-20:00 (Wuhou Shrine) / All day (Jinli) | ¥50 (Wuhou Shrine) / Free (Jinli)

Day 2 Morning: Kuanzhai Alley (宽窄巷子)

Three parallel alleys -- Wide Alley (宽巷子), Narrow Alley (窄巷子), and Well Alley (井巷子)

-- showcasing Qing Dynasty architecture with modern cafes, galleries, and teahouses.

Try a traditional Sichuan ear-cleaning service (掏耳朵, ¥30-50) from masters who've

practiced for decades. Don't miss the Sichuan Opera teahouse for a quick face-changing

performance.

24/7 (outdoor area) | Free (entry)

Day 2 Afternoon: Sichuan Hotpot Experience

Chengdu is the birthplace of hotpot -- you can't leave without trying it. Head to

Shujiuxiang Hotpot (蜀九香)

or

Dalongyi Hotpot (大龙燚)

-- both are local institutions. Order the yuānyāng guō (鸳鸯锅, half spicy / half mild) if you can't handle full málà (麻辣, numbing-spicy). Dip beef tripe (毛肚, máodǔ) for exactly 15 seconds -- that's the rule. Keep sour plum drink (酸梅汤) handy to neutralize the burn.

11:00-02:00 | ¥80-120/person | Must-try: 九宫格锅底, 毛肚, 鸭肠, 黄喉

## Day 3-4: Chongqing -- Mountain City Madness

Getting There: HSR Chengdu → Chongqing

The Chengdu-Chongqing HSR (成渝高铁) takes just 1.5 hours on the newest CR400AF

trains. Second class tickets are ¥154. Trains depart every 15-20 minutes from Chengdu

East Station (成都东站). Arrive at Chongqing North Station (重庆北站), which connects to Metro Lines 3, 10, and the Ring Line.

### Day 3: Hongya Cave (洪崖洞) & Jiefangbei (解放碑)

Hongya Cave is Chongqing's most iconic sight -- an 11-story stilted building complex clinging to a cliff face above the Jialing River, looking like a scene from *Spirited Away*.

Visit at sunset for the best photos. At night, the entire structure is illuminated in warm amber, reflecting off the river. Enter from the top (11th floor) and work your way down -- confusingly, you'll exit at ground level on a completely different street. That's Chongqing for you. Then walk to nearby Jiefangbei (解放碑), Chongqing's Times Square -- a massive monument surrounded by shopping malls and neon lights.

All day (best at sunset/night) | Free

### Day 4 Morning: Ciqikou Ancient Town (磁器口古镇)

A 1,000-year-old town on the banks of the Jialing River, famous for its stilted houses

(吊脚楼), mahjong parlors, and the best chén huā shēng (陈花生, spicy peanuts) in China.

The main street gets packed on weekends -- explore the side alleys for hidden temples

and teahouses. Don't leave without trying má là xiǎo miàn (麻辣小面, spicy noodles) from

the street stalls -- ¥8 for a bowl that will change your understanding of "spicy."

24/7 (outdoor area) | Free (entry)

Day 4 Afternoon: Chongqing Hotpot -- The Real Deal

Chongqing hotpot is different from Chengdu's -- more intense, more oily, and uses the

jiǔgōng gé (九宫格, nine-grid pot). Try

Zhou Junma Hotpot (周师兄火锅)

near Jiefangbei or

Pipa Yuan Hotpot (枇杷园火锅)

on Nanshan -- the open-air mountain-top setting with city views is unforgettable. Order the signature dishes: 毛肚 (beef tripe), 鸭肠 (duck intestine), and 鲜鸭血 (duck blood tofu).

11:00-02:00 | ¥80-120/person | Must-try: 九宫格锅底, 毛肚, 鸭肠, 酸梅汤

## Day 5-6: Zhangjiajie -- Avatar Mountains

Getting There: Flight or HSR to Zhangjiajie

From Chongqing, the fastest option is a 1.5-hour flight to Zhangjiajie Hehua Airport

(张家界荷花机场, DYG) -- tickets from ¥400-800. Alternatively, take a train via Huaihua

(怀化) -- about 6-7 hours total. From the airport, it's 30 minutes by taxi (¥50) to the

Wulingyuan scenic area entrance.

Day 5: Zhangjiajie National Forest Park (张家界国家森林公园)



This is the place that inspired James Cameron's Avatar -- towering sandstone pillars rising 200+ meters through misty clouds, draped with vegetation. The park is massive (4,810 hectares) -- you need 2 full days minimum. Day 5 focuses on the

Yuanjiajie (袁家界)

area -- the "Avatar Hallelujah Mountain" (哈利路亚山, officially called the "South Sky Pillar" 南天一柱) is here. Take the Bailong Elevator (百龙天梯, the world's tallest outdoor elevator at 326m, ¥72 one way) up to the plateau. Walk the Yuanjiajie loop trail (2-3 hours) for views of the First Bridge Under Heaven (天下第一桥) -- a natural stone bridge connecting two pillars. Also visit the Enchanting Platform (迷魂台) for the most dramatic pillar panoramas.

07:00-18:00 | ¥225 (4-day pass) + ¥72 (Bailong Elevator one way) | ! Buy the 4-day pass -- you'll need it

Day 6 Morning: Golden Whip Stream (金鞭溪) & Tianzi Mountain (天子山)



Start early at Golden Whip Stream -- a 7.5 km valley trail along a crystal-clear stream running between towering sandstone pillars. The morning mist makes the pillars look like they're floating. The hike is flat and easy (2-3 hours). Then take the cable car up Tianzi Mountain (天子山, ¥72 one way) for the "Imperial Writing Brush" peaks (御笔峰) -- the most photographed view in the park. The "Sea of Clouds" (云海) phenomenon on rainy mornings is otherworldly.

07:00-18:00 | Included in 4-day pass | 天子山索道 ¥72 one way

Day 6 Afternoon: Zhangjiajie Glass Bridge (张家界大峡谷玻璃桥)

The world's longest and highest glass-bottomed bridge -- 430 meters long, 300 meters above the canyon floor. Walk across and look down through the transparent glass panels at the forest canopy below. If that's not enough adrenaline, try the bungee jump (¥2,998) or the "walk of faith" zipline. The bridge is in a separate scenic area from the

national park -- about 1 hour drive from Wulingyuan. Book tickets online 2-3 days ahead

-- they limit daily visitors to 8,000.

07:30-17:00 | ¥228 (bridge + canyon) | ! Book 2-3 days in advance online

#### Day 6 Option: Tianmen Mountain (天门山)

If you prefer to skip the Glass Bridge, Tianmen Mountain offers equally spectacular

thrills. Take the world's longest cable car (7,455m, 30 minutes) from Zhangjiajie city

center to the summit at 1,518m. Walk the glass skywalk (玻璃栈道) clinging to the cliff

face, then descend through the Tianmen Cave (天门洞) -- a massive natural archway in

the mountain, reached by 999 steep steps. The 99 Bends road (通天大道) with its hairpin

turns is visible from the cable car.

08:00-17:00 | ¥278 (entry + cable car round trip)

#### Day 7: Return

Depart from Zhangjiajie Hehua Airport (flights to major cities) or take the train via

Changsha or Huaihua. If time allows, stop at Changsha for a few hours of Hunan cuisine

(see the Zhangjiajie → Fenghuang → Changsha route for details).

## Route Tips

\* Spice Survival:

\* You'll encounter three levels of spicy -- Sichuan's *málà* (numbing-spicy), Chongqing's oily-hot, and Hunan's *xiāng là* (fragrant-spicy). Order *wēi là* (微辣, mild) until you're sure.

Keep yogurt and sour plum drink handy.

\* Transport:

\* Chengdu-Chongqing HSR is frequent and cheap. Chongqing-Zhangjiajie is best by flight (1.5h). Within Zhangjiajie, hire a local driver (¥300-500/day) -- the park entrances are far apart.

\* Weather:

\* Zhangjiajie is famous for mist and rain -- this actually makes it MORE beautiful (the floating mountain effect). Bring a rain jacket. Summer (June-August) is hot and humid but lush. Spring and autumn are ideal.

\* Budget Estimate:

\* ¥5,000-8,000 per person for 7 days (mid-range). Zhangjiajie park tickets + cable cars + elevators can total ¥600+. Flights Chongqing-Zhangjiajie: ¥400-800.

\* Essential Apps:

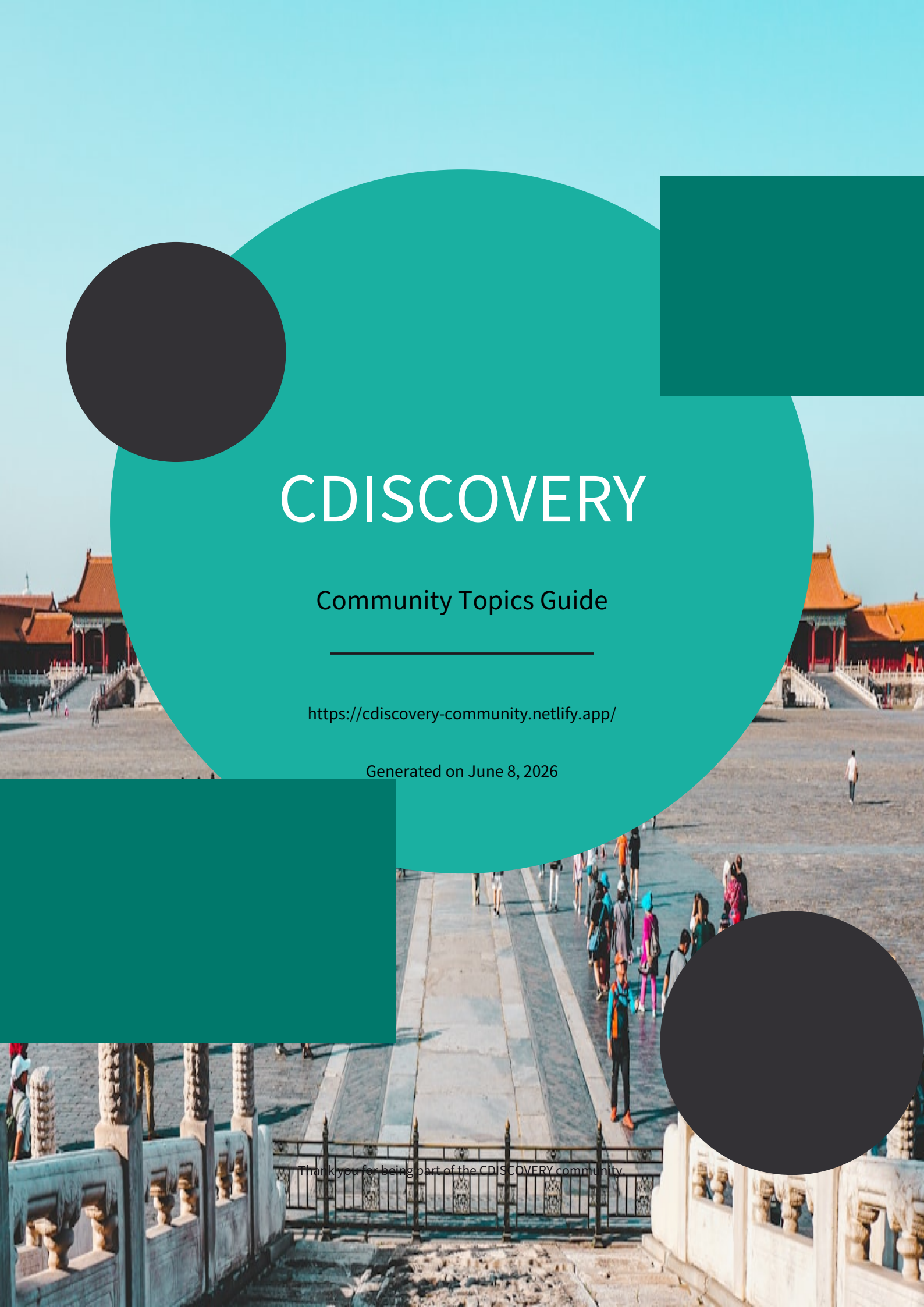
\* 高德地图 (navigation), 12306 (train booking), 美团 (food delivery & deals), WeChat Pay / Alipay (payments).

\* Where to Stay:

\* In Zhangjiajie, stay near Wulingyuan (武陵源) entrance rather than the city center -- it's closer to the park and has more guesthouse options.

Sources: Sources: [China Conservation and Research Center for](https://www.panda.org.cn)

Giant Panda • [12306 Official Railway](https://www.12306.cn) • [Chongqing Tourism](https://www.cqtpb.com) • [Zhangjiajie Tourism](https://www.zjjtravel.net)



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